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I

What does trust mean in Japanese Culture?

1. On a scale of 1-5, 1 being not important and 5 being extremely important. How important is proper business card exchange (meishi koukan) for making good first impressions in Japan?
2. What happens when someone consistently fails to 'read the air' (kuuki yomeni) in Japanese workplaces?
3. In your country how important is it to socialize with coworkers outside of work hours in order to establish trust? Follow up - And what kinds of activities are most effective in creating these stronger bonds?
4. When getting to know a new colleague, what matters more for trust: their individual performance, or their ability to work well with the team?
5. Can you describe how a shared background, like graduating from the same university, affects trust between colleagues?

Rationale:
These questions stem from research by Javidan and Zaheer (2021) showing that Asian cultures, especially Japan, prioritize relationship-oriented trust criteria over performance-oriented ones. According to their fieldwork, trust is difficult to establish when coworkers are unable to recognize "faint or implied social cues" (Javidan & Zaheer, 2021, p. 4). They specifically highlight Japan's emphasis on "reading the air" (kuuki yomeni) as a factor in trustworthiness. Relationship-building is even more important in Japan, where "in Japan, people tend to have lower generalized trust" (Yamano et al., 2024). According to recent research, "the Japanese approach of building trust, employee loyalty, recognizing employee accomplishments, decentralizing decision making, and employing consensual decision making" is still a key component of organizational culture (Tang et al., 2000). These results are consistent with Hofstede's (2001) cultural dimensions, which emphasize group harmony and established relationships. Japan scores highly on collectivism and uncertainty avoidance.

II

What does effective communication mean in Japanese Culture?

1. In Japan, how important is non-verbal communication such as eye contact, gestures and body language in everyday interactions? Follow up - Could you share an example?
2. In a meeting, if someone disagrees with a popular idea, how would they usually express it?
3. What communication practices are considered polite or respectful when meeting someone for the first time in Japan?
4. How is respect shown non-verbally when speaking to someone senior in a meeting?
5. In group settings, is it customary to speak freely, or only when directed to?

Rationale

These questions are based on research showing that communication in Japan is highly context-driven, with much of the meaning expressed through silence, body language, and indirect signals rather than direct words (Hall, 1976). The tatemae/honne concept reflects the complexity of Japanese interpersonal communication (Benedict, 1946; Davies and Ikeno, 2002). Everyday interactions often rely on subtle cues, making it important to “read between the lines” to fully understand what is being said (Barnlund, 1975). In conflict situations, people generally avoid open confrontation, instead using indirect approaches to protect harmony (wa) and relationships (Gudykunst & Nishida, 1994). Respectful communication practices—such as bowing, using honorific language (keigo), and exchanging business cards—continue to be important in first meetings and set the tone for trust (Hendry, 2013). Social hierarchy and seniority also play a big role, shaping how people address one another and how decisions are communicated (Hofstede, 2001; Nakane, 1970). Overall, effective communication in Japan is built on respect, subtlety, and maintaining harmony within social and professional settings.

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